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THE FIGHTBACK
(From left clockwise) Telangana CM KCR at a BRS meeting in Hyderabad; Mamata at an anti-BJP protest rally in Calcutta; AAP's Arvind Kejriwal and Bhagwant Mann in Chennai to solicit the support of Tamil Nadu CM M.K. Stalin against the Centre's ordinance on Delhi

in UP, along with the anxiety among JD(U) leaders in Bihar, the growing discord in the DMK in Tamil Nadu and the BRS in Telangana, and the split in the NCP and Shiv Sena, will prevent the Opposition alliance from gaining momentum. On paper, the Opposition combination appears formidable and can jeopardise the BJP's math in some states. But leaders in the saffron party question the chemistry among these players. There are enough cracks in AAP to ensure that the party remains the misfit in the combination. Says Nadda, "The Opposition is uniting only on the issue of *parivarwaad* (family). It is only saving its dynastic successors, whether it's the Congress, Sharad Pawar, Lalu, Stalin or Mamata. They will fail because of their own inner contradictions."

Meanwhile, the BJP is restructuring both its national as well as state units. In the first week of July, it came up with a list of four new state unit chiefs. Apart from Kishan Reddy for Telangana and Purandeswari for Andhra, Babulal Marandi was made president of the Jharkhand state unit and Sunil Jakhar was given Punjab. In Jharkhand, which has 14 Lok Sabha seats, Marandi, a former CM, was brought in to challenge chief minister Hemant Soren and make it a Santhali vs Santhali contest. The BJP had tried to hit Soren too with ED cases for money laundering but so far the chief minister has stood his ground and even risen in stature. He is now an important leader for the Opposition's unity moves. In Punjab, Jakhar, a former Congress leader, is seen as a rural face to help it win support across the state's villages and small towns.

Apart from these states, the BJP's biggest test before the general election is the assembly election in Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan later this year. Though the Congress won a majority in all three states in the 2018 assembly poll, the BJP swept the general election the next year, winning 61 of the 65 seats in these states. The biggest worry for BJP leaders is Chhattisgarh. The Congress government headed by Bhupesh Baghel is facing anti-incumbency, but the BJP doesn't have leaders in place to challenge him.

In neighbouring MP, CM Shivraj Chouhan has been in the saddle for close to 18 years in total and faces voter fatigue. But he remains the state's best-known leader and its strongest OBC face and that has kept the party from replacing him so far. The other issue in MP is that the assimilation of Congress MLAs who had defected to the BJP along with their leader Jyotiraditya Scindia has not been smooth. Scin-